

THE CONCEPT OF EVIL

Greetings, my dearest friends. May this lecture again prove helpful, and thus a blessing. May these words shed light and clarification in your groping and in your search towards liberation.

Tonight I should like to discuss a topic that I have, so far, touched upon only indirectly. It is the concept of evil. Traditional religion postulates and implies that evil is a separate force by itself. According to this concept, man has to cope with the decision between good and evil. Some philosophies postulate that there is no such a thing as evil, that evil is only an illusion and that in reality it does not exist. This is often misunderstood, even by the very proponents of this philosophy. The denial of manifestations of evil is as illusory as the belief that evil represents a separate aspect in the universe.

I would like to present a deeper understanding of this concept, in this lecture, which will be extremely helpful for all of my friends who are deeply involved with the processes of self-finding.

Evil is, or results from, numbness and a confusion about the execution of control. Why is evil numbness? When you think of the defense mechanisms constantly found operating in the human psyche, the connection between numbness and evil will become quite clear. The child who feels hurt, rejected, helplessly exposed to pain and deprivation, often finds numbing of his feelings the only protection against suffering. This is often, quite realistically, a useful protective device. The same applies to circumstances in the life of a child that it cannot understand. When it is confused and perceives contradiction and conflict, equally contradictory emotions result in its own psyche. The child cannot cope with either. Numbness is also a protection against its own contradictory responses, impulses, and reactions. Under such circumstances, this might even be a salvation. But when such numbness has become second nature and is maintained long after the circumstances have changed, and when the personality is no longer a helpless child, in the smallest measure it is the beginning of evil, and this is how evil is born.

Numbness and insensitivity towards one's own pain in turn means equal numbness and insensitivity towards others. When examining one's reactions closely, one might often observe that the first spontaneous reaction to others is a feeling for and with them, a compassion or empathy, a participation of the soul. But the second reaction restricts this emotional flow. Something clicks inside and seems to say no. The result is a protective layer of unfeelingness. In that moment, one stands separate, apparently "safe," but separate. Later, this may be overcompensated for with false sentimentality, with dramatization, with unguine, exaggerated sympathy. But this is only a substitute for the numbness. The numbness, instituted for oneself, must be continued towards others just as every attitude towards the self is bound to expand towards others.

We might differentiate three stages of numbness. First is the numbness towards the self as protective mechanism. The second is the numbness towards others. In this stage, it is a passive attitude of indifference. It enables one to see others suffer without the discomfort of any pangs. Much of the world's evil is caused by this state of soul. Just because it is less crass, in the long run it is more harmful, for active cruelty induces quicker counterreactions. Passive indifference, however, born out of numbness of feelings, can look on for a long time and go by unnoticed because it can so easily be camouflaged. It permits the person to follow his most selfish impulses without open detection. Indifference may not be as actively evil as committed cruelty, but it is as harmful in the long run.

The third stage is one of actively inflicting cruelty. This stage comes about due to fear of others who seem to expect such acts; or due to an inability to cope with pent-up rages; or due to a subtle process of strengthening the protective device of numbness. Offhand, this may appear incomprehensible. But when you think of it deeply, you will find that man may occasionally, almost consciously, stand on the brink of a decision: "Either I allow my feelings to reach out in participation with the other, or, in order to refuse this strong influx of warm feelings, I have to behave in the exact opposite way." The next moment, such reasoning is gone, the conscious decision forgotten, and what remains is a compelling force towards cruel acts.

In all these instances, it can be seen again and again how all harm, all destructiveness, all evil, results from the denial of the spontaneous real self, substituting secondary reactions which in one way or another are always connected with fear.

The borderline between passive numbness and active infliction of cruelty is often a very thin and precarious one, very much dependent upon apparently outer circumstances. If man understands these processes, not only intellectually, but within himself, he is adequately equipped to cope with the world's cruelty, which so often gives rise to despair, doubt, and confusion within himself.

When active cruelty is committed, it is an increased numbing process, prohibiting not only the influx of spontaneous positive feelings, but it also is supposed to ward off fear and guilt. The active deed of inflicting pain on others simultaneously kills off one's own ability to feel. Hence, it is a stronger device to attain numbness.

There must always be a differentiation between the active deeds -- of either indifference or cruelty -- or the existence of these trends in the emotional reactions. Even the indifference or numbness may not actively be executed. It is possible that a person may experience this nonparticipation and numbness but not act upon it. He may do all he can in order to help another -- perhaps often even overdo just because he does not wish, on the conscious level, to be so indifferent. The desire to hurt others may exist merely as an emotion, without ever being acted upon. Guilt does not differentiate between these vital manifestations and seems to say that it makes no difference whether the person feels or acts in destructive harmful ways. Hence, the entire trouble area is denied, pushed out of consciousness where it can no longer be corrected. Admitting, acknowledging, facing an emotion, no matter how undesirable, can never harm the self or others and is bound to eventually dissolve it. Confusing the impulse with the deed and therefore denying both, results in extreme disturbance of the self, and therefore indirectly affecting others, with no hope of change so long as the process remains unconscious.

Seen in this light, it will be clear that numbness, to its extreme and followed to its logical end, becomes active cruelty. The difference between these two is only one of degree. It is exceedingly important for you, my friends, to understand this. For he who is most shocked, afraid of, and unable to cope with the existing cruelty in the world, he who suffers most by the mere knowledge that it exists, is inevitably the person who has in some way made himself numb and suffers from the guilt of its consequences. Therefore there must be a correlation between one's numbness and one's approach or attitude to the evil aspects of life. Some may be overly burdened, some may be overly sentimental, still others may be overly tough and indifferent about the existence of evil. Whatever overreaction exists in this respect must be connected with the numbness that, in some respect, has been instituted in the psyche. At one time, it seemed as the only available protection; later it was unwittingly maintained.

The second facet of evil is the question of control. In different contexts, we have discussed this topic many times. We discussed the importance of relinquishing too tight a control, while failing to use those controls and powers which the personality has at its disposal for the purpose of attaining a full, rich life. The imbalance this creates induces rigidity where flexibility should exist, and a helpless loss of self where resilient firmness should prevail. The imbalance is always caused by the ignorance and lack of differentiation between outer and inner self. All this has been discussed repeatedly. But we never linked this with the question of evil.

All suffering occurs by dint of helplessness. The greater the helplessness, the less the personality is able to avoid pain. The child is, by its very nature, helpless, weak, dependent. Hence, the suffering it may experience requires means, such as the numbing process, to weaken the impact of what comes to the little personality without its being able to do something about it.

The helplessness continues to exist in the adult where his psyche has remained childish or immature. The trouble spots in one's inner life are always marked by this feeling of utter helplessness, while in the healthy areas, this feeling is absent. It is obvious that helplessness and lack of control are very much connected. Since helplessness causes pain, pain causes numbness, and numbness leads to evil; it becomes clear that imbalance and lack of control is also connected with evil.

On a broader scale, helplessness is one of the most problematic aspects of mankind. The significance of this is vastly overlooked. Man even feels the helplessness towards his own body. There is a considerable area where man has control. This area extends to the degree that man has found his inner self, or real self. Where he is distorted and the real self is hidden from his outer awareness, control ends. It is then that man feels helpless, weak, afraid.

The relationship between man's body, man's feelings, and man's personal life circumstances is the same from the point of view of control. Man has a direct control over certain of his bodily functions. He can move his outer muscles at will. He can determine with his outer, or ego self, when and how to use certain muscle controls, when and how to move. In fact, a number of his physical functions are under the direct jurisdiction of his outer will and cannot work unless outer will is exerted. To summarize, all outer organs are under the direct control of his outer ego.

But there is a vast area of his body the outer will cannot directly reach. These functions are not under the jurisdiction of outer will. They work in perfect order without any deliberate or determined action of will on the part of man. They cease to function well without any apparent determination of man's outer will. The inner bodily functions are not governed by outer control. This is frightening for man because he does not understand it. He feels he has no power over a vast area of his body; he seems at the mercy of his own body, as it were.

The same applies to psychic processes. Man has indisputable control over a vast area of his actions, over the words he speaks, over the choice of his thoughts. But he seems to have no control over the spontaneous reactions of his feelings. This, too, can be quite frightening. He may want to feel one thing, but cannot make himself to do so. He may hate to feel another emotion, but is unable to prevent it. From suppression and repression, as you all know, strange and even more disquieting compulsions arise with the result of making him feel even more helpless in the grip of his own personality. Even though such thoughts may not be put into concise words, the fact remains that he often feels in some such way as: "If I do not even have jurisdiction over my body and over my own reactions and feelings, if within myself a frightening power seems to be at work which I do not know and cannot control, how much more helpless must I be in regard to life as such?!"

Actually, the correlation between the self and life is a very direct one, as I have often explained and as can be demonstrated again and again when getting to know one's hidden areas. Man does not have any more control over the faculties of his inner body and psychic processes than he has over his life, nor does he have less. To the extent that he has found the key to his inner processes, to that extent has he found the key to the apparently fateful occurrences governing his life.

Unfathomable fate seems to control man's inner body, man's spontaneous reactions, and a number of outer circumstances. But is it true that man must be separated from his inner faculties? Does he really have no control over his inner functions? Or can a connection be established between his consciousness and his inner body, his spontaneous feelings and his life?

As to his life, the same relationship exists as is outlined between body and feelings. He has direct control over certain happenings. His outer, direct will can determine certain actions which he knows are bound to produce certain effects. If he does this, it must have that effect. But then, as with the body and the world of his feelings, comes an area where this immediate direct control ceases. Hence, the relationships between man's body, man's inner world of feelings, and man's outer life are all the same. They are all divided by a borderline of where he has obvious direct influence of molding events and results; and where this seems not to be so, but where a power appears to be at work over which he has no jurisdiction, he does not understand and therefore fears. Due to this idea that a strange power, independent from himself, seems to play with him, the concept of an outer God has arisen -- a God who needs to be implored and appeased. Finding the true nature of this power is the ultimate aim of man's spiritual development.

The spirit knows that man's destiny is to find the nature of this power, to extend his power over his own fate. But this message, coming from the depths of his spiritual being, often reaches the outer regions of the personality in a mangled, distorted way, due to all the existing misconceptions and confusions. He strives towards this end, but he does so in the wrong way. He often attempts it

by tensing his outer will and trying to assert it over regions over which it has no jurisdiction. He misdirects the will faculties of his outer ego.

Those of you, my friends who, throughout years of effort in this pathwork, have realized stages of growth, have come to the occasional experience that where you were helpless before, you are no longer helpless at all. You not only discover powers, strength, resourcefulness, and adequacies with which to successfully cope with life, qualities you never dreamed you possessed, but you also begin to see that a remote control seems to be at work, governing your fate, your outer life circumstances. You realize that your control expands. You experience that the areas of noncontrol recede. These new found areas of control are not under the jurisdiction of direct control, but work by remote control.

This extension of control does not, cannot happen through a rigid tightening of the ego forces -- of will, or mind, or reasoning, or mental processes. It is, as I said, an indirect process of remote control, which eventually becomes direct control. To be more specific, your ego faculties have to be used but not in the way this is usually attempted. They can and must be used in order to diminish the strength of outer will. The idea that outer will is omnipotent must be relinquished, and the outer faculties must entrust themselves to the inner man.

Offhand, this may appear confusing or even contradictory, but when comprehended more deeply, you will undoubtedly come to understand, once again, the process of this work we are involved with here. When you learn to use your mind with the understanding that there is a vaster intelligence, very immediately accessible within yourself -- no far away deity separated from you, but an immediate and integral part of yourself -- when you realize this, you will experience that what I said here is true. You will see, first, remote control working where there was absolutely no intervention, connection, or control. And eventually remote control will gradually turn into more direct control. At first, this cannot be more than a theory you must test with good faith, willingness, and openness. Later, the theory is bound to turn into fact, into experienced reality.

If you wish to exert control over areas not accessible to your outer will -- for example, inner body processes -- you overexert yourself, weakening your energies and courting disappointment and frustration. If you understand, however, that all inner processes -- inner body, inner feelings, and inner life, manifesting in fate apparently coming from outside -- can be governed only by the inner man, you will not waste valuable ego energy in the wrong direction. Instead, you will use your outer mind to make contact with the inner self so that it does what needs to be done. When you realize this, you are in keeping with that which is feasible.

Now, how can the inner self be activated? It cannot be activated by itself, for it responds only to consciousness. Your entire consciousness (outer as well as inner) has the power to direct this inner being with all its marvelous resourcefulness, with its intelligence and power. This inner being, in turn, has jurisdiction over the inner processes. Man has no inkling about the limitless possibilities, extending far, far above and beyond what he believes to be "natural law."

When this is understood, the true significance of life, the true significance of meditation will then be absorbed, lived, experienced. There will no longer be a problem or confusion in the use of faculties that have no bearing on or jurisdiction over live functions. What is vastly overlooked is that the limitations of the outer ego faculties exist only as long as it is ignored that these same ego

faculties must be used for the purpose of directly contacting the inner man, who then in turn takes on the job of performing with and for all inner faculties -- body, feelings, apparent fate. The outer consciousness must be used in order to activate the inner consciousness. In spite of the tremendous power of the latter, it responds only to a direct, deliberate effort of the outer mind. It is this indirectness that establishes what I have called remote control.

It begins to work more and more as the personality removes distortions and misconceptions that are embedded in the psyche. It is these distortions that create a barrier between the outer and the inner consciousness. But as more insight is gained, more understanding attained, and, little by little, destructive attitudes change, the cooperation between the outer and inner self extends the areas of control. At first, this appears almost coincidental. Occasional certainties are put in doubt again by unavoidable relapses. You know quite well that the process of growth is not that problems disappear in one sweep. It happens bit by bit. Remnants remain, which continue to act up until all distortions disappear. Then gradually, what was once an unconnected fate one was helplessly exposed to, one had no jurisdiction over, gradually becomes, more and more visibly so, cause and effect by remote control as opposed to the direct control of outer faculties. And as development goes on, remote control becomes more and more direct. Then inner and outer faculties become one. And as this process continues, control is no longer a problem -- when to let go of the outer ego faculties, the tight overcontrol that has to be relinquished, and when to use outer will in the proper way.

Nor is it necessary any longer to numb oneself so as to cope with helpless exposure to pain. For there is no longer helplessness.

Now, my dearest friends, the absorption, understanding, the knowing, and experiencing of what I said to you here is of great importance for every one of you, for your pathwork.

Are there any questions now?

QUESTION: I would like to connect what you said with a problem in me. It seems to me that I have a tendency to feel overburdened by the existing cruelty. Going back to my childhood, I discovered that one of my pseudosolutions is to withdraw. Now, when I do withdraw, I automatically withdraw my love. Is there guilt involved in this?

ANSWER: Yes, this is true. But it also has other ramifications. As I explained in this lecture, when you withdraw love, you become numb. This numbness, although it was a protective shield during childhood against cruelty from the outside, does not prevent the existence of negative emotions in the inner make-up, such as rage, fear, anger. These emotions cannot be numbed. They can only be hidden. This then increases guilt. For one feels, if one were to translate what is taking place in the personality: "Here I am, fearing the cruelty from the outside, fearing the rage and the indifference of the world. The injustice of others is due to their insensitivity to me. In my fear of this injustice, this insensitivity, indifference, cruelty, and rage, I make myself as numb as they must be." The guilt expresses clearly that one resents in others what one feels compelled to perpetuate, in the misunderstanding that a similar, even though disguised, trend is a protection. The psyche says, "I stop myself from warm, loving feelings, so as to protect myself. In spite of the numbing effect on certain emotions, I cannot insensitize rage and anger in me." This, then, compounds the guilt.

QUESTION: The physical functions which are beyond our control, is it this rage and anger as well as guilt which create sickness?

ANSWER: Of course. Let me put it this way. All destructive emotions which are underground, which exist hiddenly, create problems, hazards, difficulties whether this manifests in the physical, emotional, or mental system, or in the outer life circumstances of a person. It is true that these hidden negative emotions, as a result of distorted values and wrong concepts, create illness. But it is also true to state that the ignorance of the power within, the ignorance of the fact that the outer self has recourse over the inner self, creates a state of helplessly enduring instead of correcting, healing, improving, and preventing negative occurrences in the future. When one feels the victim of fate, of powers outside one's control, one is likely to overlook the most obvious and direct resources.

The knowledge that the outer and inner self have to cooperate in order to bring order, harmony, truth, and fulfillment will enable an individual to use his energies in the right direction. It is the inner being which builds, maintains, and reinstitutes health. Ignoring its presence and its power must make man a helpless victim. It is the inner being which can create a constructive life in which everything is given that is needed from the outside because no inner barriers exist. It is the inner person who has to be contacted with the faculties of will and mind of the outer person. This should be done very simply and directly. But what stands in the way must be removed. The removal, too, happens faster and more adequately when the inner being is enlisted.

Let us finish this lecture with the following suggestion for meditation. Let us combine the aspects discussed tonight: control through the inner being and giving up the unconscious deliberate numbness. The way to approach the relationship between the outer ego faculties of mind and will, and the inner being for the purpose of eliminating numbness might be the following: "My outer direct will faculties cannot reach those areas in which I have numbed my faculties of perception, of experience, of feeling, and of sensitivity. Therefore I wish to contact my inner being of higher intelligence and greater power than my outer mind, to take the necessary steps to defreeze these faculties, to bring them to life so that I will become a fully functioning human being. Wherever there is fear and misconception involved in this respect, I wish to understand them so that I may eliminate what stands in the way. It is the useless prohibitions I do not yet quite know which cause me to be only partially alive. I want to be fully alive. In order to bring this about, I contact the inner self to help eliminate obstructions, to bring to my consciousness what I need to know so that I will reawaken and live in the state of fulfillment, selfhood, and beauty."

You do not need to repeat these words exactly. Use your own words, your individual way of verbalizing and expressing the essence of these thoughts. This would be the approach, my friends.

Be blessed, every one of you, in the continuation of your path. May you feel, every one of you, the light of truth and love that life could be if you so choose. If when you take the right and constructive steps so as to integrate the outer and the inner being through actively establishing a contact between them, life could be infinitely more than you could wish for. Life is no more and no less than what you allow it to be, the best or the worst or the many grades in between. Life is no more and no less than that which your consciousness expresses. The limits you set to your fulfillment, similar to the limit you believe exists regarding control, are entirely arbitrary. They depend on your belief. To the extent that you know the powers of your inherent faculties, to that

extent will you possess the world. But these inherent powers dwell in the inner person, not in the outer ego self.

The extent of the realization of your inner faculties depends on the sum total of your consciousness, on your beliefs, your concepts, your expressions. All this in turn depends on the degree your inner being is free to manifest or to the extent it is obstructed. When you have numbed your feelings, the inner self is inactivated. It alone is capable of making you and life one, in the best sense of the word.

Be in peace, be in God!

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